Module 1
Introduction to Modern Art & Ideas

Module 2
Places & Spaces

Module 3
Art & Identity

Module 4
Transforming Everyday Objects

Introduction to Transforming Everyday Objects
- Welcome to Module 4 — Reading • 10 min
- Transforming Everyday Objects — Video • 4 min

Transforming How Objects Look
- How do artists draw from their surroundings? — Reading • 20 min
- Ruth Asawa. Untitled (BMC. 145, BMC Laundry Stamp). c. 1948-49 — Video • 1 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Noah Purifoy. Unknown. 1967 — Video • 2 min

Transforming What Objects Mean
- How do artists alter the meaning of objects? — Reading • 10 min
- Alfonso Ossorio. Empty Chair or The Last Colonial. 1969 — Video • 2 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Diamond Stingily. Entryways. 2021 — Video • 1 min

Transforming What Objects Do
- How do designers problem-solve? — Reading • 10 min
- Clara Porset. Butaque Chair. 1957 — Video • 2 min
- Tomás Gabzdil Libertiny. The Honeycomb Vase "Made by Bees" (Prototype). 2006 — Video • 2 min

Review & Reflect
- Optional Readings & Resources — Reading • 10 min
- Assessment: Transforming Everyday Objects — Dialogue • 15 min
- Optional Prompts for Discussion & Reflection — Reading • 10 min

Module 5
Module 5: Art & Society

Introduction to Art & Society
- Welcome to Module 5 — Reading • 10 min
- Art & Society — Video • 4 min

Responding to Society
- How do artists and designers respond to social conditions? — Reading • 10 min
- Dorothea Lange. Migrant Mother. 1936 — Video • 2 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Jacob Lawrence. Migration Series. 1940-41 — Video • 2 min

Challenging Society
- **How do artists challenge social conditions?** — Reading • 10 min
- Ernest Cole. Untitled. c. 1960 — Video • 2 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Martha Rosler. House Beautiful (Bringing the War Home). 1967-72 — Video • 2 min

Shifting Perspectives
- How do artists and designers shift perspectives? — Reading • 10 min
- Hanes, Inc. White T-Shirt. 1910s — Video • 2 min
- Gilbert Baker. Rainbow Flag. 1978 — Video • 3 min

Review & Reflect
- Optional Readings & Resources — Reading • 10 min
- Assessment: Art & Society — Dialogue • 15 min
- Optional Prompts for Discussion & Reflection — Reading • 10 min

Module 6
Course Conclusion

How do artists challenge social conditions?

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Jasper Johns. *Flag*. 1955. Encaustic, oil, and collage on fabric mounted on plywood, three panels, 42 1/4 x 60 5/8" (107.3 x 153.8 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Philip Johnson in honor of Alfred H. Barr, Jr. © 2016 Jasper Johns/Licensed by VAGA, New York, NY

"It all began...with my painting a picture of an American flag," Jasper Johns said in 1959 about this work. When Johns made *Flag*—using oil paint and encaustic (pigment in hot wax) on newspaper clippings, and fabric—the United States government was seeking out suspected Communists in the Second Red Scare. At this charged time, the American flag was a potent symbol.

While Abstract Expressionist artists stripped painting of overt references to the real world, Johns boldly used one of the most recognizable symbols of all. He broke with the notion that painting was a means of abstract personal expression and incorporated into his work what he described as "things the mind already knows." But he also carried forward abstraction in the gestural brushstrokes that break apart the flag's pattern into a textured surface. One critic encapsulated this work's ambivalence, asking: "Is this a flag or a painting?"



Emory Douglas. *The Black Panther Newsletter*, vol. 4, no. 13 (Our main purpose). 1970. Two color ink on newsprint, 17 5/8 × 11 1/2" (44.8 × 29.2 cm). Black Panther Party. Collection of Patrick and Nesta McQuaid and Akili Tommasino, gift of the Committee on Architecture and Design Funds. © 2024 Emory Douglas / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York

"Art is a powerful tool, a language that can be used to enlighten, inform and guide to action," Emory Douglas has said. As the former Minister of Culture and Revolutionary Artist for the Black Panther Party, Douglas helped define the aesthetics of protest at the height of the Civil Rights era, cementing his status among the 20th century's most influential political artists.

Throughout the 1960s and 1970s, Douglas designed all but one of the Party's newspapers, each issue marked by the artist's bold, figurative illustrations outlined with thick black lines and contrasted with bright colors, block text, and photomontage. The clearly rendered imagery—applied to a range of printed media from newspapers to posters, notecards, and pins—became a hallmark of liberation movements around the world. "We had a readership of 400,000. The solidarity came in the artwork, it spoke a language that transcended borders."



Felix Gonzalez-Torres. *"Untitled" (Perfect Lovers)*. 1991. Clocks, paint on wall, overall 14 x 28 x 2 3/4" (35.6 x 71.2 x 7 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of the Dannheisser Foundation. © 2016 The Felix Gonzalez-Torres Foundation, Courtesy Andrea Rosen Gallery, New York

Felix Gonzalez-Torres made *"Untitled" (Perfect Lovers)* at the height of the HIV/AIDS crisis in the United States. His boyfriend of eight years, Ross Laycock, died of AIDS-related illness the same year he made this work. While *"Untitled" (Perfect Lovers)* grew out of his own experience of love, partnership, and loss, its meaning is universal.

Simple in its construction, it consists of two clocks hung side-by-side and touching on a pale blue wall. Gradually, the clocks go out of sync. This subtle, elegant presentation may be read as a metaphor for the progress of the life of a couple and the consequences of time, which can introduce disharmony, illness, and the decay of perfection into that life. "We…have to trust the viewer and trust the power of the object," Gonzalez-Torres once said about his choice of imagery. "And the power is in simple things….It keeps thought from being opaque."



Michael Rakowitz. paraSITE homeless shelter. 1997. Polyethylene, 42" x 36" x 11' (107 x 91.5 x 335 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Michael Rakowitz and Lombard-Freid Projects

Michael Rakowitz addresses history, current events, and pressing social problems with his art. With paraSITE homeless shelters, he aims to offer some relief to unhoused people and to agitate for policy changes that would permanently solve the problem of homelessness. Each shelter is custom-made, and the design process begins with a conversation between the artist and the occupant. One occupant was an avid science-fiction fan, who requested that his shelter be shaped like Jabba the Hutt. Another wanted plenty of windows so that he could remain vigilant against potential attackers.

After finalizing the design, Rakowitz builds the structure out of materials including Ziploc bags, packing tape, and, in his later models, sheets of polyethylene, a common plastic valued for its toughness, lightness, and flexibility. Like parasites in nature, the paraSITE shelters need resources extracted from an external source in order to function. They attach to the air outtake ducts of buildings, which serve as the "host" from which they derive the warm air that heats and inflates their structures.

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